

CHINAR DAYS
Deepa Soni at 'The Autumn Art Exhibit' in Srinagar, Nov. 26, 2022

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DEEPA SONI, 38
ARTIST AND FASHION DESIGNER
Srinagar

Her ties with Kashmir began long before she moved there. Originally from Patiala in Punjab but settled in the garrison town of Udhampur in Jammu, Deepa Soni's family would for decades buy Pashmina shawls and papier mache articles from an itinerant merchant whom they knew as Farooq Baba of Tangmarg. The tradition had run in his family for several generations, and his greatest fear was that it would die with their generation. The youngsters had neither the interest nor the patience to carry forward the legacy.

An artist at heart, Soni would always be moved by Baba's story, and wanted to do something for artisans like him. Her opportunity came when her government servant husband was posted to Srinagar in 2021. Soni began conducting free workshops for skilled and amateur craftspersons, especially young women from the rural hinterland. "From eight to 80," says Soni, "my workshops began attracting people across age groups."

Soon top artisans began lauding her efforts. "I met with the older generation of artists and have worked with them to create new designs and colours so that the crafts met contemporary standards without losing their originality," adds Soni, who is spending her second season of the *chillai kalan*—the harshest period of the Kashmiri winter—in the Valley. "My work is to encourage and inspire the younger lot to return to the *karkhanas* (workshops). Kashmiri handicrafts need no introduction across the world. My techniques, designs and patterns in embroidery enhance their market value."

Soni is also helping keep tradition alive, particularly of the oldest craft in the Valley—the GI-tagged Kani shawl, which has a provenance dating back to Mughal times. Made of the finest Pashmina sourced from the Changthang goats found in the high reaches of Ladakh, the shawls derive their name from the place of their origin—Kani-